FREE GUIDE

Gluten-Free Meal Planning Made Simple

Stop Googling Substitutes — Here's the Complete Cheat Sheet

- Safe Grains Guide
- Flour Substitution Chart
- 7-Day Meal Plan
- Label Reading Tips

EVOFIT MEALS

Gluten-Free Basics

Gluten is a family of proteins found in wheat, barley, and rye. It gives bread its chewy texture and helps dough rise. For some people, eating gluten triggers serious health issues — for others, avoiding it is a lifestyle preference. Here's what you need to know.

? What Exactly Is Gluten?

Gluten is composed of two proteins — **glutenin** and **gliadin** — that form an elastic network when flour is mixed with water. It's found in **wheat** (including spelt, kamut, farro, durum), **barley**, **rye**, and **triticale**. Oats are naturally gluten-free but are often cross-contaminated during processing.

Three Reasons People Go GF

Celiac Disease

Autoimmune disorder where gluten damages the small intestine lining. Affects ~1% of the population. Even trace amounts cause harm. **Requires strict lifelong avoidance.**

Gluten Sensitivity

Non-celiac gluten sensitivity (NCGS) causes bloating, fatigue, and brain fog without intestinal damage. Estimated 6–7% of adults. **Symptom-managed avoidance.**

Lifestyle Choice

Some people report better energy and digestion without gluten. No medical requirement, but still benefits from knowing safe foods. **Flexible approach.**

! Hidden Sources of Gluten

These Foods Secretly Contain Gluten

These are the sneaky ones that catch people off guard — always check labels.

- **Soy sauce** — brewed with wheat (use tamari instead)
- **Beer & malt beverages** — barley-based
- **Salad dressings** — wheat-based thickeners
- **Marinades & sauces** — flour as thickener
- **Imitation crab** — wheat starch binder
- **Seasoning blends** — anti-caking agents with wheat
- **Soup & broth** — flour-thickened bases
- **Candy & licorice** — wheat flour coating
- **Processed meats** — fillers & binders
- **Communion wafers** — wheat-based

Safe Grains & Starches

Going gluten-free doesn't mean giving up grains entirely. These naturally gluten-free options are nutritious, versatile, and widely available. Here's what to stock in your pantry — with protein and fiber per cooked cup.

White Rice
4g protein • 0.6g fiber
Neutral flavor, pairs with everything

Brown Rice
5g protein • 3.5g fiber
Nutty flavor, more nutrients

Quinoa
8g protein • 5g fiber
Complete protein, all 9 amino acids

Oats (Certified GF)
6g protein • 4g fiber
Must be labeled gluten-free

Potato
4g protein • 3.5g fiber
High potassium, versatile prep

Corn / Polenta
5g protein • 4g fiber
Great for tortillas & sides

Buckwheat
6g protein • 4.5g fiber
Not wheat — it's a seed

Millet
6g protein • 2.3g fiber
Mild, fluffy, easy to cook

Tapioca
0.3g protein • 0g fiber
Great thickener & binder

Also Safe

- **Arrowroot** — starch thickener (0.1g P, 0g F)
- **Sorghum** — ancient grain (10g P, 6g F)
- **Amaranth** — high protein seed (9g P, 5g F)
- **Teff** — Ethiopian grain (10g P, 7g F)
- **Sweet potato** — nutrient-dense (4g P, 6.5g F)

A Note on Oats

Oats are naturally gluten-free, but conventional oats are almost always cross-contaminated with wheat during growing and processing. **Always buy oats labeled "Certified Gluten-Free"** from brands like Bob's Red Mill GF, GF Harvest, or Avena Pure Oats.

Flour Substitution Guide

One of the trickiest parts of going gluten-free is replacing wheat flour. Every alternative behaves differently — some absorb more liquid, some don't bind well. This chart gives you exact ratios and best-use scenarios.

GF FLOUR	RATIO TO WHEAT	BEST FOR	NOTES
Almond Flour	1:1	Cookies, cakes, pancakes	Dense, moist. Add extra egg for structure.
Coconut Flour	1/4 : 1	Muffins, quick breads	Very absorbent. Triple the liquid. Use extra eggs.
Rice Flour	7/8 : 1	Breading, thickening sauces	Gritty alone. Blend with tapioca starch.
Oat Flour (GF)	1:1	Cookies, pancakes, crumbles	Make your own: blend GF oats. Mild flavor.
Cassava Flour	1:1	Tortillas, flatbreads, pizza	Closest wheat texture. AIP-friendly. Nut-free.
Tapioca Starch	2 Tbsp : 1 Tbsp	Thickening, chewy texture	Use as partial blend. Creates stretch & chew.
Buckwheat Flour	1:1	Pancakes, crepes, noodles	Strong earthy flavor. Mix 50/50 with rice flour.
Arrowroot Starch	1 tsp : 1 Tbsp	Thickening sauces, gravies	Better than cornstarch for acidic sauces.

Pro Tip: The GF Blend Formula

For an all-purpose GF flour blend that works in most recipes, mix:
2 cups rice flour + 2/3 cup potato starch + 1/3 cup tapioca starch.
Add 1 tsp xanthan gum per cup of blend for binding.

Binding Without Gluten

Gluten provides structure. Without it, add binders:
- **Xanthan gum** — 1 tsp per cup of GF flour
- **Psyllium husk** — 1 Tbsp per cup (bread)
- **Flax egg** — 1 Tbsp ground flax + 3 Tbsp water
- **Extra eggs** — 1 extra egg per recipe

7-Day GF Meal Plan

Real meals that don't feel restrictive. Every item is naturally gluten-free — no specialty products needed. Built for ~1,800 calories/day with balanced macros.

Monday

1,810 cal • 145g P • 185g C • 62g F

BREAKFAST	GF oat bowl with banana, almond butter & chia seeds	420 cal
LUNCH	Grilled chicken rice bowl, black beans, avocado, salsa	560 cal
SNACK	Apple slices with almond butter, rice cakes	250 cal
DINNER	Baked salmon, roasted sweet potato, steamed broccoli	580 cal

Tuesday

1,790 cal • 138g P • 192g C • 58g F

BREAKFAST	Scrambled eggs (3) with spinach, GF toast, avocado	440 cal
LUNCH	Turkey lettuce wraps with quinoa, shredded carrot, tamari	480 cal
SNACK	Greek yogurt with mixed berries & GF granola	280 cal
DINNER	Stir-fry beef with rice noodles, bell peppers, tamari sauce	590 cal

Wednesday

1,820 cal • 142g P • 198g C • 56g F

BREAKFAST	Smoothie: banana, protein powder, spinach, almond milk, PB	380 cal
LUNCH	Baked potato loaded with chili, cheese & sour cream	540 cal
SNACK	Hummus with carrots, cucumber & corn tortilla chips	260 cal
DINNER	Grilled shrimp tacos on corn tortillas, mango salsa, slaw	640 cal

Thursday

1,780 cal • 148g P • 178g C • 60g F

BREAKFAST	GF oat pancakes (3) with blueberries & maple syrup	430 cal
LUNCH	Quinoa salad with grilled chicken, feta, cucumber, olives	510 cal
SNACK	Hard-boiled eggs (2) & handful of mixed nuts	270 cal
DINNER	Herb-crusted pork tenderloin, mashed potatoes, green beans	570 cal

7-Day GF Meal Plan continued

Friday

1,800 cal • 140g P • 190g C • 58g F

BREAKFAST	Sweet potato hash with eggs (2), peppers & onions	410 cal
LUNCH	Rice paper rolls with shrimp, rice noodles, peanut dipping sauce	490 cal
SNACK	Banana with sunflower seed butter, dark chocolate (2 squares)	290 cal
DINNER	Lemon herb chicken thighs, jasmine rice, roasted zucchini	610 cal

Saturday

1,830 cal • 135g P • 200g C • 64g F

BREAKFAST	Buckwheat crepes with ricotta, fresh berries & honey	420 cal
LUNCH	Mexican bowl: brown rice, ground turkey, corn, beans, guac	580 cal
SNACK	Trail mix: GF pretzels, almonds, dried cranberries	240 cal
DINNER	Pan-seared cod, polenta cakes, sauteed asparagus & cherry tomatoes	590 cal

Sunday

1,850 cal • 150g P • 188g C • 62g F

BREAKFAST	Veggie frittata (eggs, peppers, mushrooms, cheese) + fruit	450 cal
LUNCH	Thai peanut chicken with rice noodles & steamed bok choy	560 cal
SNACK	Cottage cheese with pineapple & toasted coconut flakes	230 cal
DINNER	Grilled steak, baked potato with butter, Caesar salad (GF dressing)	610 cal

Meal Prep Sunday

Cook rice, quinoa, and proteins in bulk on Sunday. Store in glass containers. Most meals above take under 20 minutes when grains and proteins are prepped. **Batch-cooking is the secret to sustainable gluten-free eating.**

Adjust to Your Goals

This plan targets ~1,800 cal/day. To **cut:** reduce rice/potato portions by 1/3. To **bulk:** add an extra snack and increase protein portions by 30%. Need personalized macros? EvoFit Meals calculates them for you.

Reading Labels Like a Pro

Knowing safe ingredients is only half the battle. You need to decode packaging, understand certifications, and navigate restaurants safely. Here's your cheat sheet.

✓ Certification Symbols to Trust

GF — **GFCO Certified** — Gluten-Free Certification Organization. Products test below 10 ppm gluten. The gold standard. Look for the circular "GF" logo.

CSA — **CSA Recognition Seal** — Celiac Support Association. Annual testing, strict facility audits. Trusted by celiac community.

NSF — **NSF Gluten-Free** — NSF International certification. Independent lab testing at <20 ppm. Common on supplements.

FDA — **"Gluten-Free" Label (FDA)** — Must contain <20 ppm gluten. Not third-party verified — relies on manufacturer testing. Acceptable but less rigorous.

! Red Flags on Ingredient Lists

Avoid These Words

- Wheat, barley, rye, triticale
- Malt, malt extract, malt syrup
- Brewer's yeast
- Modified food starch (if from wheat)
- Hydrolyzed wheat protein
- Seitan, fu (wheat gluten)
- Semolina, durum, einkorn, spelt

Cross-Contamination Warnings

- "Made in a facility that also processes wheat"
- "May contain wheat/gluten"
- "Processed on shared equipment"

For celiac: avoid these products. The warnings are voluntary — companies who include them are being honest, but the risk is real.

For sensitivity: usually safe, but note how you feel.

★ Restaurant Survival Tips

Do

- Call ahead and ask about GF prep areas
- Request grilled proteins with no marinade
- Ask for rice, potato, or corn-based sides
- Use apps: Find Me GF, Nima sensor
- Tip well — servers who help are gold

Don't

- Assume "wheat-free" means GF
- Trust fried foods (shared fryer oil)
- Forget sauces & dressings (ask for plain)
- Feel embarrassed asking questions
- Skip the allergy card (carry one!)

READY FOR THE NEXT STEP?

Get Custom Gluten-Free Meal Plans Built for Your Body

Stop guessing portions and Googling substitutes. EvoFit Meals gives you personalized GF meal plans with exact macros, grocery lists, and prep instructions — all tailored to your goals.

STARTER	PRO	PREMIUM
$9 / mo	$19 / mo	$39 / mo
Basic meal plans	Custom macros + grocery lists	1-on-1 coaching included

Start Your Free Trial

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- ✓ Gluten-free focused plans
- ✓ Personalized macros
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